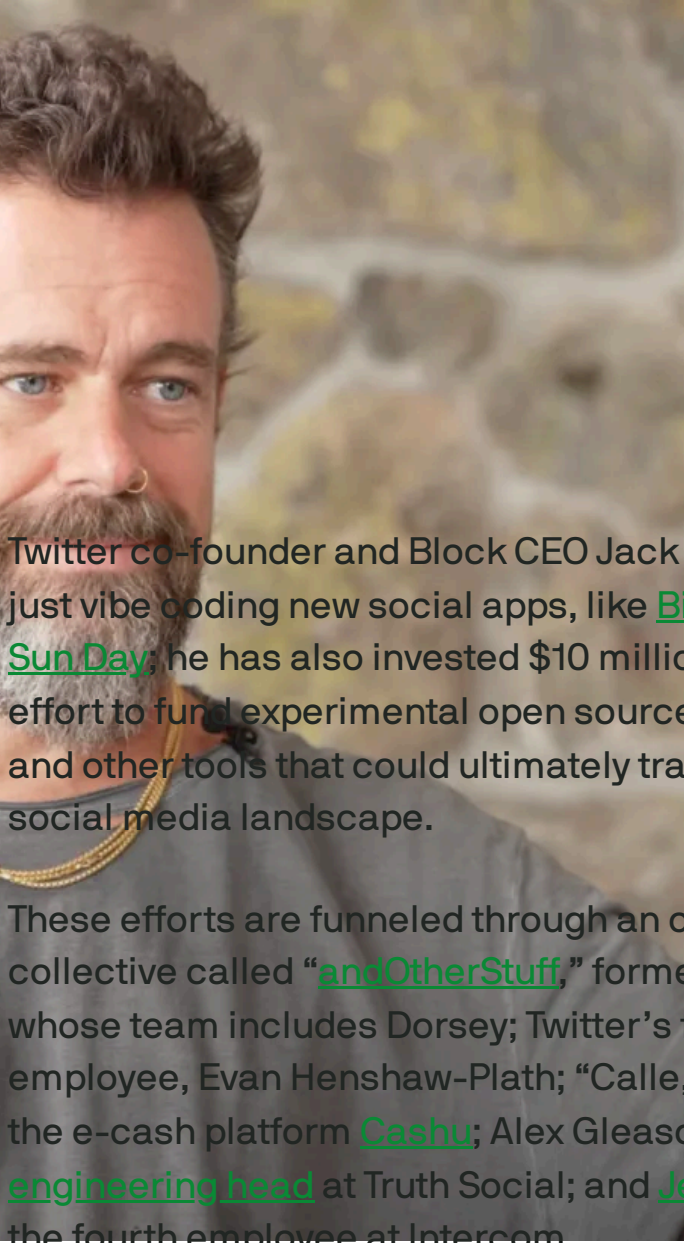


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SOCIAL



**Jack Dorsey pumps
\$10M into a nonprofit
focused on open source
social media**



Sarah Perez — 9:01 PM PDT · July 16, 2025

Twitter co-founder and Block CEO Jack Dorsey isn't just vibing coding new social apps, like [Bitchat](#) and [Sun Day](#); he has also invested \$10 million in an effort to fund experimental open source projects and other tools that could ultimately transform the social media landscape.

These efforts are funneled through an online collective called "[andOtherStuff](#)," formed in May, whose team includes Dorsey; Twitter's first employee, Evan Henshaw-Plath; "Calle," creator of the e-cash platform [Cashu](#); Alex Gleason, former [engineering head](#) at Truth Social; and [Jeff Gardner](#), the fourth employee at Intercom.

IMAGE CREDITS:

[SCREENSHOT VIA REVOLUTION.SOCIAL](#)

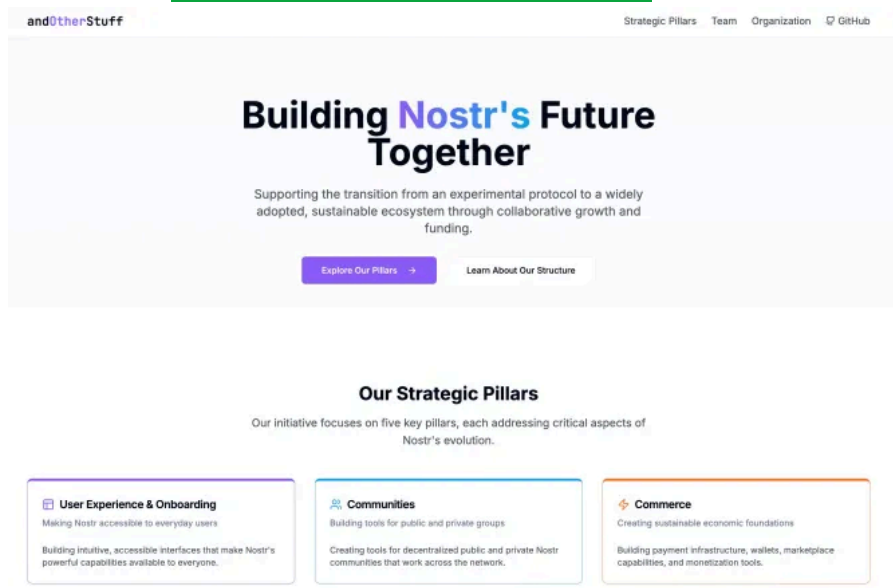


IMAGE CREDITS:AND OTHER STUFF

The group originally met through collaborating on [Nostr](#), an open, "apolitical" social networking protocol that has been receiving the bulk of Dorsey's attention since [Twitter's sale to Elon Musk](#)

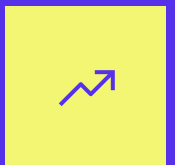
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and his [stepping down from social network Bluesky's board](#). However, the team will experiment with other tools, too, like ActivityPub, the protocol that powers the decentralized app Mastodon and others, as well as Cashu.

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IMAGE CREDITS: CASHU

In recent years, Dorsey has [been more critical](#) of how social media platforms have evolved, saying that [Twitter should have never been a company](#) and that Bluesky seemed to be [repeating the mistakes](#) he and others made at Twitter.

As a result, the team at “andOtherStuff” is determined not to build a company but is instead operating like a “community of hackers,” explains Henshaw-Plath. Together, they’re working to create technologies that could include new consumer social apps as well as [various experiments, like developer tools or libraries](#), that would allow others to build apps for themselves.

For instance, the team is behind an app called [Shakespeare](#), which is like the [app-building platform Lovable](#), but specifically for building Nostr-based social apps with AI assistance.

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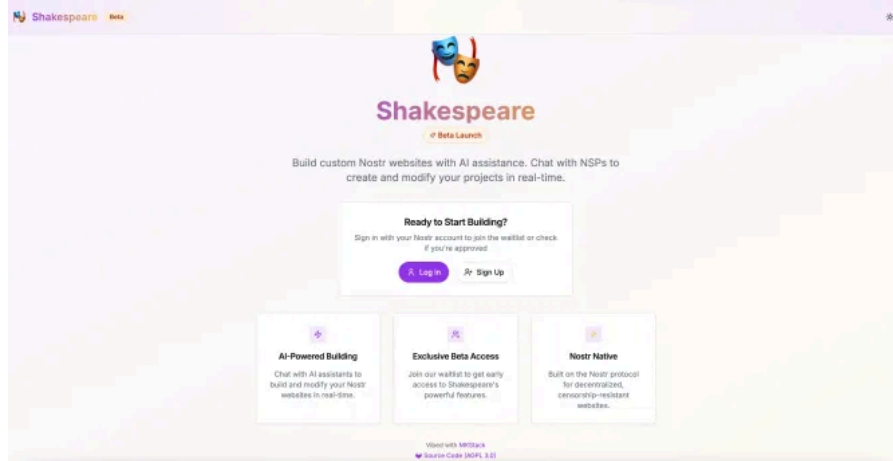


IMAGE CREDITS: SHAKESPEARE

The group is also behind [heynow](#), a voice note app built on Nostr; [Cashu wallet](#); private [messenger](#) [White Noise](#); and the Nostr-based [social community + chorus](#), in addition to the apps Dorsey has already released.

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Developments in AI-based coding have made this type of experimentation possible, Henshaw-Plath points out, in the same way that technologies like Ruby on Rails, Django, and JSON helped to fuel an earlier version of the web, dubbed [Web 2.0](#).

Related to these efforts, Henshaw-Plath sat down with Dorsey for the debut episode of his new podcast, [revolution.social with @rabble](#). (Henshaw-Plath's handle on X is [@rabble](#).)



Since Dorsey lives in Costa Rica and Henshaw-Plath lives in New Zealand, the two met up at a hackathon in Switzerland for the chat. In the nearly hour-long episode, Dorsey delves into Twitter's history as well as his philosophies around where social media went wrong and how it can be fixed.

"It took me a long time to realize this ... I didn't really put it into words until I came back as CEO the second time. But it's hard for something like [Twitter] to be a company, because you have corporate incentives when it wants to be a protocol," Dorsey says. He notes that Twitter was at the mercy of its advertisers — something Musk also faces despite taking Twitter, now called X, private. Musk has even threatened advertisers with [lawsuits](#) over ad boycotts driven by their concerns over X's lack of moderation and controversial comments Musk has made.

While Dorsey understands that catering to advertisers was correct for the business and for Twitter's stock price, it was the "wrong thing for the internet."

"They can just remove the money — your money — and your revenue goes down completely," Dorsey

says of advertisers' power. "So if [Twitter] were an open protocol, if it were truly an open project, you could build a business on top of it, and you could build a very healthy business on top of it."

Dorsey eventually funded an effort to build an open protocol inside Twitter, which later spun out to become Bluesky. But Dorsey believes Bluesky faces the same challenges as traditional social media because of its structure — it's funded by VCs, like other startups. Already, it has had to [bow to government requests](#) and [faced moderation challenges](#), he points out.

"I think [Bluesky CEO] Jay [Graber] is great. I think the team is great," Dorsey told Henshaw-Plath, "but the structure is what I disagree with ... I want to push the energy in a different direction, which is more like Bitcoin, which is completely open and not owned by anyone from a protocol layer. That's what I see in Nostr as well," he says. "That's where I want to push my energy ... into the more corporate direction, even if it is a public benefit corporation," Dorsey adds.



IMAGE CREDITS: [ANDOTHERSTUFF](#)

In later episodes, Henshaw-Plath will interview others who have insight into how social media and tech have evolved, including journalists like Kara Swisher and Taylor Lorenz; former Twitter head of

Trust and Safety Yoel Roth; Substack co-founder Chris Best; Medium CEO Tony Stubblebine; [Cory Doctorow](#) (who coined the term “[enshittification](#)” to describe the state of much of the current web); and renowned misinformation researcher Renée DiResta.

The team at “andOtherStuff” is also working on a [social media “Bill of Rights,”](#) says Henshaw-Plath, which spells out what social media platforms [need to provide](#) in areas like privacy, security, interoperability, transparency, identity, self-governance, and portability.

This, they believe, will help platforms, including Bluesky and others, remain accountable to their users despite any outside pressure.

Dorsey’s initial investment has gotten the new nonprofit up and running, and he worked on some of its initial iOS apps. Meanwhile, others are contributing their time to build Android versions, developer tools, and different social media experiments.

More is still in the works, says Henshaw-Plath.

“There are things that we’re not ready to talk about yet that’ll be very exciting,” he teases.

Topics: [Apps](#) [jack dorsey](#) [nostr](#) [Social](#)

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MICHAEL M. SANTIAGO / GETTY IMAGES

SOCIAL



The ‘vote Trump’ spam that hit Bluesky in May came from decentralized rival Nostr

Sarah Perez — 10:44 AM PDT · May 21, 2024

Decentralized social networks aren’t immune to botnet-driven spam, as a recent spam attack on Bluesky demonstrates. Earlier this month, a flood of posts reading “remember to always vote Trump” showed up on Bluesky’s network posted by accounts with random names and default avatars.

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The spam didn't originate on Bluesky, though. Instead, it reached Bluesky by first crossing over two other decentralized networks: Mastodon and Nostr. To do so, the botnet leveraged "bridges," or pathways built between the networks that make them interoperable.

Though the spam attack occurred on May 11, a postmortem by a data scientist only published a few days ago, gaining the event increased

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Nostr, which he finds to be a more open protocol.

It may seem strange, but even though Nostr and platforms like Mastodon and Bluesky are all decentralized networks, they don't actually talk to one other. Mastodon uses the ActivityPub protocol, which is now also being adopted by Meta in [Instagram Threads](#), and other apps and services including [Flipboard](#) and open-source Substack rival [Ghost](#).

To allow posts from one network to pass through to another, bridges are being built. Already, that's been a point of contention between [some decentralized social networking users](#) as different groups have argued about how the bridges should

be built while others question whether bridges should even exist in the first place.

The latter group could now point to this recent event as an example of the downsides of bridges, as the botnet smartly leveraged bridges to spam another network.



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According to the analysis of the attack, the Nostr spam was sent first to Mastodon via the bridge Momostr.pink. Then, another bridge called Bridgy Fed sent the content from Mastodon to Bluesky.

“Fingerprints of this process appear in the Bluesky versions of the posts, where the account handles have the format npub.momotr.pink.ap.brid.gy,” wrote [conspirator0@newsie.social](#) on [Substack](#).

“The first portion of this (from npub until the first dot) is the public key of the Nostr account, while the remainder (momotr.pink.ap.brid.gy) contains some indications as to the tools used to bridge the posts (Mmomotr and Bridgy Fed).”

The botnet was able to post the “vote Trump” spam continuously until Bluesky took action against the spam accounts. The dataset for analysis was incomplete because Bluesky began removing accounts while the data was being gathered. Still, from what was collected, it seems that at least 228 accounts managed to post 470 times in a matter of just six hours. Around half of those were “vote Trump” posts while others posted “hello world” with a random adjective sandwiched in between the two words.

Bluesky mitigated the attack fairly quickly and took down the spam accounts. The company hasn’t yet responded to requests for comment about whether it will change its approach to spam or bridges.

As the site The Fediverse Report pointed out, this sort of spam attack was possible because [Nostr makes it particularly easy to create new accounts](#).

The incident once again raises the question as to what the fediverse — that is, decentralized social media — actually is. If you join Bluesky, are you consenting to be part of a network that includes Nostr content? Does Bluesky’s network include Mastodon, because a bridge has been built?

These are questions that don’t have solid answers as of yet.

Topics: [bluesky social](#) [Mastodon](#) [nostr](#) [Social spamming](#)

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APPS



Jack Dorsey-backed Twitter alternative Bluesky hits the App Store as an invite-only app

Sarah Perez — 11:06 AM PST · February 28, 2023

IMAGE CREDITS: [JOSE A. BERNAT BACETE](#)
/ GETTY IMAGES

[Bluesky](#), the Twitter alternative backed by Twitter co-founder and CEO Jack Dorsey, has [hit the App Store](#) and more testers are gaining access. Though the app is still only available as an invite-only beta, its App Store arrival signals that a public launch could be nearing.

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We haven't heard much from Bluesky [since October 2022](#), when the team behind the project shared an update on the Bluesky blog, detailing the status of the social protocol that powers its new Twitter-like app, also called Bluesky.

AT (originally called ADX, or "Authenticated Transfer Protocol,") is [Bluesky's](#) main effort while the Bluesky mobile app serves to showcase the protocol in action. Similar to the ActivityPub protocol that powers Mastodon, [AT](#) offers the means of creating a federated and decentralized social network. However, there's been [some criticism of the project](#), notably from Mastodon and other developers, who pointed out that ActivityPub — a [recommended W3C standard](#) — already powers a large and growing "Fediverse" of interconnected servers.

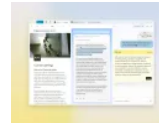
And *that* Fediverse has been gaining traction following Musk's Twitter acquisition, as users left the microblogging network to try [the open source, decentralized alternative, Mastodon](#). The latter has also benefited from the work of former Twitter third-party app developers who have since rolled out polished Mastodon clients like [Ivory](#) and [Mammoth](#), most recently.

Other companies have also committed to or at least discussed embracing the ActivityPub standard, including [Flipboard, which announced its plans today](#), as well as [Medium](#), [Tumblr](#) and possibly [Flickr](#). Where that leaves Bluesky's future is unclear.

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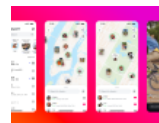
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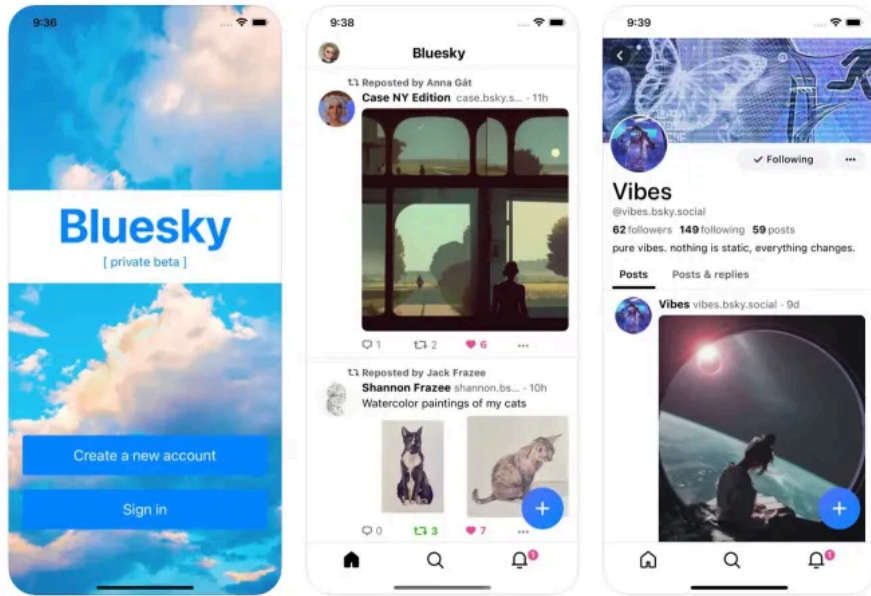


IMAGE CREDITS: BLUESKY ON APP STORE

The Bluesky project, now a public benefit company, had [originally been incubated within Twitter](#) starting [in 2019](#) when Jack Dorsey served as CEO. Twitter also provided its [financial backing for years](#). Though its founding was well ahead of the company's sale to current owner Elon Musk, the two execs more recently had discussed the idea of an open source protocol [over text messages](#) ahead of Musk's Twitter acquisition.

In texts, Dorsey explained to Musk that a “new platform is needed. It can't be a company. This is why I left [Twitter].” (Dorsey exited the CEO role at the [social network in November 2021](#) but [remained on Twitter's board](#) through May 2022.)



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Shortly after giving up his CEO duties, Dorsey took to Twitter to publicly talk about Bluesky, describing it as “an open decentralized standard for social media.” That discussion had taken place around the time when [Dorsey was sharing his thoughts about](#) Twitter’s decision to ban President Trump from its platform. Bluesky, he believed, would reduce the ability for large, centralized platforms — like Twitter — to have so much power in terms of deciding which users and communities could engage in speech and who would be responsible for moderating that content.

But with Musk now at the helm of Twitter, [it’s not clear](#) if or how the two projects may remain intertwined. Bluesky [last year](#) said it had received [\\$13 million](#) to ensure it had the freedom and independence to get started on R&D and noted Jack Dorsey was on its board. It also said Twitter’s funding of Bluesky was “not subject to any conditions except one: that Bluesky was to research and develop technologies that enable open and decentralized public conversation.”

Today, however, Twitter has been drastically cutting its costs, including [through layoffs, auctions, office closures](#) and even not [paying its bills](#). It would be surprising if a side project like Bluesky would remain a priority.

Twitter's funding of Bluesky is not subject to any conditions except one: that Bluesky is to research and develop technologies that enable open and decentralized public conversation.

Hands-on with Bluesky

Now the [Bluesky app](#) is out publicly and some users are being invited to try it. According to app intelligence firm [data.ai](#), the Bluesky iOS app debuted on February 17, 2023 and has somewhere north of 2,000 installs. Given its invite-only status, this likely represents only the newly added beta testers at this time. The app isn't yet ranking on any Top Charts in the U.S., and it's not available on Google Play.

We received an invite to the service and found it to be a functional, if still rather bare-bones, Twitter-like experience.

Users create a handle which is then represented as @username.bsky.social as well as the display name that appears more prominently in bold text, as on Twitter.

IMAGE CREDITS: BLUESKY SCREENSHOT;

WHO TOOK MY HANDLE?

As a brand-new app, Bluesky's suggested user list didn't immediately impress with big names of public figures during onboarding. Mastodon, meanwhile, has managed to attract more high-profile individuals in the wake of the Musk-prompted Twitter exodus, by comparison.

The app itself presents a simplified user interface where you can click a plus button to create a post of 256 characters, which can include photos. (Though, unlike Mastodon, it doesn't prompt you for alt text for accessibility's sake).

Where Twitter asks “What’s happening?,” Bluesky asks “What’s up?”

You can search for and follow other individuals, much like on Twitter, then view their updates in a Home timeline. User profiles contain the same sort of features you’d expect: a profile pic, background, bio and metrics, like the number of followers and posts a user has, as well as how many people they’re following. Profile feeds are also divided into two sections, like Twitter: posts and posts & replies.

IMAGE CREDITS: BLUESKY SCREENSHOT

Bluesky users can share, mute and block accounts, but advanced tools, like adding them to lists, are not yet available.

The discover tab in the bottom center of the app's navigation is useful, offering more “who to follow” suggestions and a running feed of recently posted Bluesky updates. The latter gives you the opportunity to find more people who you might like to follow, based on their posts rather than just a bio.

Posts themselves can be replied to, retweeted, liked and, from a three-dot menu, reported, shared via the iOS Share Sheet to other apps, or copied as text.

Another tab lets you check on your Notifications, including likes, reposts, follows and replies, also much like Twitter. There are no DMs.

The app was experiencing a bug when we tested, showing errors when you try to click into various sections at times, but a Bluesky developer replied to our post that a fix was coming in an hour. (As Bluesky is not open to the public, this is easily forgivable.)

There's something ironic about leaving Twitter to use an app that looks and feels so much like Twitter, right down to posts from Jack Dorsey as he muses over product concerns like "density of info," character count or in-app navigation. Bluesky's larger promise is the new underpinning technology of the AT protocol, but the app itself feels like a stripped-down Twitter.

In a way, it's nice to be away from Twitter's mean tweets, crypto scams and clout-chasing posts (including from its new owner). But there are already so many Twitter clones now in the works, including the yet-to-launch-publicly projects like [T2](#), [Spill](#) and [Post](#); it's hard to imagine carving out time to use another app, as well. (Of course, if Twitter adopted AT, things could get more interesting. But who knows what Musk is up to these days.)

IMAGE CREDITS:

BLUESKY SCREENSHOT OF @JACK

Arguably, some are not sold on the promise that the web needed another decentralized protocol that serves the same purpose as ActivityPub, either. After all, a million little Fediverses is not the decentralized web of our dreams.

Hey [@jack](#) and [@bluesky](#), feel free to check out these GitHub repositories. Might make this unique idea y'all have of a decentralized "Twitter" a bit easier to bring to fruition.
<https://t.co/tHXeaATUMM>
<https://t.co/QJsYpUfAKk>

— Mastodon (@Mastodon@mastodon.social)
(@joinmastodon) [December 11, 2019](#)

Bluesky's plans to run a beta were first announced in October, but the app itself was not publicly available at the time.

Bluesky declined to comment or answer further questions about the project, app or beta, noting it's not doing press at this time as it's focused on working through bugs.

Updated 2/28/23 2:44 PM with additional background about Bluesky's financial backing.

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